

ESSENTIAL GAN FACT SHEET

Newton Kids – Operational Briefing for HQ and Decision makers

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WHAT IS ESSENTIAL GAN?

An **essential gan** is an emergency childcare framework that operates under Home Front Command (HFC) Annex I' ("Exceptions") and the Ministry of Education's national procedure for children of essential workers during emergencies.

Legal basis:

- HFC Protection Policy (16 March 2026), Annex I', sections on "מעונות יום" (day-care centres) and "מסגרת מפ"ל" (emergency frameworks for children of essential workers).
- Ministry of Education: "Response procedure for children of essential workers in an emergency" ([MoE procedure PDF](#)).
- Daycare Supervision Law regulations.

Purpose:

To enable essential workers to continue working in critical sectors (health, security, infrastructure) by providing childcare when regular educational settings are closed.

AGE GROUPS COVERED

Essential gan frameworks serve **two distinct age bands**, each with different rules:

Age group	Framework name	Regulations
0–3 years (birth to 36 months)	מעונות יום (day-care centres for essential workers)	Daycare Supervision Law + MoE emergency procedure
3–12 years	מסגרת מפ"ל (emergency framework, often school- or community-based)	MoE emergency procedure

Centres with both 0–3 and 3–6 provision can run **both types of groups** in parallel, each following its relevant rules.

WHO IS ELIGIBLE? DEFINITION OF ESSENTIAL WORKERS

Legal definition:

A child of an essential worker is eligible if **at least one parent** works in a facility or organization formally classified as "essential" under Israeli emergency law.

Essential sectors include (non-exhaustive):

- Healthcare (hospitals, clinics, pharmacies)
- Security and emergency services (IDF, police, fire, Magen David Adom)
- Energy and utilities (electricity, water, fuel)
- Food production and supply chain
- Communications and media

- Financial and banking services
- Public transport and logistics
- Local authorities and government ministries
- Construction and infrastructure (where approved)

Official resources:

- Check if an employer is defined as essential: <https://did.li/Xbhba> (Ministry of Labor list)
- Home Front Command essential-workers guidance: <https://www.oref.org.il/heb/recommendations/gov>
- Full definition of essential sectors: [Essential Services Definition \(Gov.il\)](#)
- Hebrew: [הגדרות משק חיוני](#)

Additional eligibility criteria:

A child qualifies if:

1. At least one parent is an essential worker employed in a defined essential facility, **AND**
2. The parent's role is classified as essential and cannot be performed from home, **AND**
3. The other parent cannot supervise the child (because they are also working, on reserve duty, or there is sole custody), **AND**
4. There is no alternative care arrangement available to the family.

VERIFICATION OF ELIGIBILITY

Eligibility should be checked using a two-step process:

Step 1: Cross-check employer against essential-workplace list

- Parent provides name of employer and sector.
- Centre checks whether the employer appears on the Ministry of Labor essential-facilities list: <https://did.li/Xbhba>.

Step 2: Employer confirmation letter

- Parent provides a brief letter or email from their employer (on company letterhead or official email) confirming:
 - The parent is employed in the organization.
 - The parent's role is classified as essential during the emergency.
 - The parent is required to work on-site and cannot fulfill their role from home.

Documentation storage:

All eligibility documentation (declaration form, employer letter, list check) will be stored securely in the child's file for audit purposes.

GROUP SIZE LIMITS

The MoE emergency procedure specifies strict group-size caps:

Ages 0–3 (day-care centres)

- **Maximum 8 children per group**
- **Minimum 2 staff** if there are more than 5 children in the group
- Groups must be **fixed and stable** (no mixing children or staff between groups during the day)

Ages 3–12 (Mafal frameworks)

- **Maximum 10 participants total per group** (children + staff combined)
- Typically means ~8 children with 2 staff
- Groups must be **fixed** for the duration of the emergency period

The Ministry of Education's caps of 8 children (0–3) and 10 participants (3–12), the requirement for fixed, non-mixing groups and the “no meals” rule all come from COVID-era emergency procedures that were designed around infection control and have not yet been updated for the current missile and rocket threat. By contrast, the current Home Front Command protection policy focuses only on civil-defence needs: it requires that all activity takes place inside or immediately adjacent to a standard protected space and that total occupancy is limited by the shelter's physical capacity (around 0.5 m² per person), without specifying group-size or catering restrictions. Our operational approach is therefore to plan group sizes and the option of providing hot meals primarily according to the HFC shelter-capacity rules, while remaining aware that the older MoE guidelines are still on the books and may be cited by inspectors until they are formally revised or replaced.

HOW MANY GROUPS CAN ONE CENTRE RUN?

There is no regulatory cap on the number of groups per site. Limits are determined by:

1. **Protected-space capacity:**
 - All children and staff on-site at any one time must fit into the centre's standard protected space (ממ"ד/ממ"ק/מקלט) within the warning time, at approximately 0.5 m² per person.
2. **Staff availability and licensing:**
 - Each group needs dedicated, qualified staff who meet MoE/MoH standards.

Centres may operate multiple groups simultaneously provided total occupancy never exceeds shelter capacity.

HOURS OF OPERATION

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he MoE procedure does not specify a maximum operating day. Operational guidance from municipalities typically specifies:

- **Half-day operation:** 08:00–13:00 (5 hours) is most common in current emergency practice.
- **Full-day operation:** 08:00–16:00 (8 hours) is permitted under the MoE procedure if staffing and resources allow.

Mandatory conditions:

- Must operate **inside or immediately adjacent to a standard protected space**.
- **No transport service** provided (parents bring and collect children).

FOOD AND MEALS

Current MoE guidance states:

- **No organized hot-meal service** in essential-worker frameworks.
- **No shared food-preparation activities** with children.
- Centres may provide **light snacks** (fruit, crackers, yogurt) and drinks.
- Parents should send a **personal packed snack and water bottle** from home.
- Children eat in the activity room (ideally the shelter or adjacent space).

Note: The no-meal guidance originates from COVID-19 protocols and has not been revised for the current emergency, but remains the official MoE instruction.

PROTECTED SPACE REQUIREMENTS

All essential-gan operation must comply with HFC shelter requirements:

- Activity takes place **inside the protected space** or adjacent with clear, unobstructed route to shelter.
- All children and staff must be able to enter the shelter **within the local warning time** (varies by location, typically 90 seconds).
- Total number of people on-site at any time must not exceed the shelter's certified capacity (approximately 0.5 m² per person).
- Shelters must be maintained, clean, and equipped with emergency supplies.

OPERATIONAL CHECKLIST

Before opening an essential gan at any centre:

- **Protected space confirmed:** Centre has a compliant מרחב/מקלט big enough for all children + staff.
- **Capacity calculated:** Total people on-site will not exceed shelter capacity (0.5 m²/person).
- **Staff qualified:** All staff meet MoE/MoH standards (first aid, child protection, relevant training).
- **Groups organized:** Fixed groups of max 8 (0–3s) or 10 total (3–12s), with at least 2 staff per group. (COVID era regulations, still on the books)
- **Eligibility process in place:** Employer list-check + confirmation letter required; secure file storage for all documentation.
- **Municipality notified:** Inform local education authority that you are operating an essential-gan under HFC Annex I' and MoE procedure.
- **Parent communication sent:** Letter/email/WhatsApp explaining hours, no transport, snack-only, eligibility criteria, verification process, and safety protocols.
- **Safety drill planned:** First-day practice of reaching shelter within warning time.
- **Emergency supplies stocked:** Water, first-aid kit, flashlight, and emergency contact lists in shelter.

KEY LINKS & RESOURCES

Resource	URL
HFC Protection Policy (16.3.26)	מדיניות התגוננות PDF
MoE Essential Workers Procedure	Response procedure PDF
Check employer essential status	https://did.li/Xbhba (Ministry of Labor)
HFC essential-workers guidance	https://www.oref.org.il/heb/recommendations/gov
Alternative location guidance	https://did.li/H1Ox5

SUMMARY TABLE

Question	Answer
What age groups?	0–3 years (day-care) and 3–12 years (Mafal framework); can run both in one centre
Group size limits?	0–3: max 8 children, min 2 staff if >5 children. 3–12: max 10 total (children+staff). Fixed groups, no mixing.
How many groups per centre?	No limit, but total occupancy must not exceed shelter capacity (0.5 m ² /person)
Hours?	Typically 08:00–13:00 (5 hours); may extend to 08:00–16:00 if resources allow
Food?	Snack-only; no hot meals; no shared food preparation; parents send packed snack
Who is eligible?	Children of essential workers (defined sectors, essential role, cannot work from home) where other parent cannot supervise
How do we verify eligibility?	Cross-check employer against Ministry of Labor list (https://did.li/Xbhba) + employer confirmation letter stating role is essential and on-site
Legal basis?	HFC Annex I' + MoE emergency procedure + Daycare Supervision Law
Protected space requirement?	All activity inside or immediately adjacent to standard protected space; total occupancy ≤ shelter capacity
Transport?	No transport service; parents bring and collect